



RKDF UNIVERSITY, BHOPAL

Bachelor of Arts (B.A.)

ODL SCHEME

First Semester Academic Session: 2024-25

Self-Learning Material of ODL

Course	Category	Subject	Subject Code
B.A.	Minor	STUDY OF Poetry	BAEN-102
Total Credit: 6		Max.Marks:100 (Internal:40+External:60)	

SYLLABUS

Units	Topic	Duration (In Hours)	Marks
I	- Introduction to Literature and its classification ...poetry from Chaucer to Milton 1.1 Figures of speech Definition of Poetry according to the Poets discussed in this paper. Different ages with different socio-economic and political backgrounds. Literary Terminology 1.2 Geoffrey Chaucer. The Wife of Bath, The Pardoner (From <i>The Prologue to the Canterbury Tales</i>) 1.3 John Donne Death Be Not Proud 1.4 John Milton On His Blindness Keywords/ Tags :Figurative language . Extended metaphor. Hyperbole, Imagery Lambic pentameter food line Narrative poetry. Metaphysical poetry Puritan era	15	25

Part- C Learning Resource

Text Books, Reference Books, Other Resources

II	Poetry in Neoclassical and Romantic Age 2.1 Alexander Pope The Rape of the Lock- Canto III 2.2 William Wordsworth Solitary Reaper. Daffodils 2.3 John Keats Ode of Autumn Keywords/Tags : <i>Nature poet, Wordsworth is theory of poetry, Spontaneity. Lyrical Ballads. Fancy and Imagination, Supernatural poetry Revolutionary poet. Sensuousness, Hellenism Negative capability Aesthetic beauty.</i>	15	25
III	Poetry in Victorian Age 3.1 Alfred Lord Tennyson Break Break Break 3.2 Robert Browning. The Last Ride Together 3.3 Matthew Arnold Dover Beach Keywords/Tags : <i>Victorian age. Industrial revolution Victorian society. Autobiographical note. Tennyson and clough, Dramatic monologue, pastoral elegy. Oxford movement Campus poetry.</i>	15	25
IV	Indian Poetry 4.1 Toru Dutt : Our Casuarina Tree. Sita 4.2 Sarojini Naidu Indian Weavers 4.3 Rabindranath Tagore: Gitanjali Song No 1 & 2 Keywords/Tags : <i>Indo- Anglican poetry simile and Metaphor, spirituality : Poetry of Indian Independence Mythological Characters.</i>	15	25

Suggested Readings:

“A History of Modern Poetry : Modernism and After” Perkins David Paperback 1989

“Glossary of Literary Terms” Abrams. M.H. Prism Books Pvt Limited 1993

“John Donne- The Major Works OWC” Carey John and Donne John UK Oxford University Press 2009 Print

“John Keat His life and poetry His friends Critics and After- fame” Colvin Sidney London Macmillan 1917.

“Letter to George and Thomas Keats 21 December 1817 and Letter to Richard Woodhouse.

27 October 1818 in Romantic Prose and Poetry” Keats John ed Harold Bloom and Lionel Trilling (New York OUP 1973) pp 766-68-777-8

“Lytical Ballads with Pastoral and Other Poems” Wordworth William (1805) (4ed)

London : Printed for Longman, Hurst Rees, and Orme, by R Taylor

“The Canterbury Tales” Chaucer, Geoffrey Trans Nevill Coghill New Delhi Penguin

Classics, 2002 Print Brown Peter Geoffrey Chaucer, OWC New Delhi Oxford University Press 2011 Print

“Toru Dutt (1856-1877) Indian Poet Translator and Novelist” Lokuge Chandan (12 September 2019 Oxford Oxford University Press

Suggested digital platforms weblinks :

Athar “Indian Poetry in English English Summary 17 Nov 2017 English summary.com/indian-poetry-in-english.

Literature mini. Com “The Brief History of English Poetry” 2018

[WWW literature mini com/2018/08/the –brief-history-of-english-poetry html](http://WWW.literaturemini.com/2018/08/the-brief-history-of-english-poetry.html)

Polly “A Brief History of English Poetry “The culture project 17 Apr 2017 the culture

Project project blog word press.com/2017/03/19/a-brief-history-of-english-poetry

Wikipedia contributors “English Poetry” Wikipedia 21 May 2021

En Wikipedia org/wiki/English_poetry

Suggested equivalent online courses :

- [https://www.edx .org/course/ap-english-literature-composition-part-2-poems-2](https://www.edx.org/course/ap-english-literature-composition-part-2-poems-2) AP English Literature and Composition, Part 2 Poems on EDX by Maggie Sokolik, University of California Berkeley
- <https://www.coursera.org/Learn/modopo> Modern and Contemporary American Poetry by AI Filreis, University of Pennsylvania
- [https://www.classcentral.com/course/ Modern American-poetry-5963](https://www.classcentral.com/course/Modern-American-poetry-5963) Modern American Poetry- Free online course

Unit I

Goeffrey Chaucer. The Wife of Bath, The Pardoner (From The Prologue to the Canterbury Tales)

OBJECTIVES

In unit 1 of the present block, a view of Chaucer’s life and works that covered the fourteenth century English society and culture as well as the poems Chaucer wrote under various heads.

In this unit, we study a part of Chaucer's text. It is called The Wife of Bath's Prologue. This forms part of The Canterbury Tales at the point where the Wife of Bath has a chance to tell the fellow pilgrims her tale; her purpose is to entertain the audience and interact with them directly, too.

This means that she could address the pilgrims, share with them details about her personal life and link these with the tale. We necessarily think about the Prologue here, an introductory piece that may add to the jovial atmosphere in which the tour to Canterbury is conducted. We shall also go into the nature of the Prologue as form, its role and function in the telling of the tale so that knowledge is earned about the Wife of Bath as a person and her attitude to the society she lived in. It is of interest for us that the Wife of Bath carries in her a story, and an autobiography. The latter is not less meaningful and valuable than the tale the Wife would present. Her views about men and women of the day and the relationship they have with one another might tickle our imagination and compel us to think about the ideological implications of her conduct.

INTRODUCTION

This unit will help us understand the meaning and message of the Wife of Bath's Prologue, that part of The Canterbury Tales where the woman in question is presented in realistic terms. In the words of Muriel Bowden, the woman is described as follows: The Wife of Bath's orderly and well set-up appearance, as has been suggested, is in keeping with the strong directness of her character. She is one who has always known exactly what she wants and exactly how to get it. She desires, and has obtained importance in her community; good times with gay companions—"In felaweshipe wel koude she laughe and carpe" (Bowden, Muriel. "The Good Wife of Juxta Bathon" in Critics on Chaucer:

This is a one line expression of her character and attitude. In the specific Prologue preceding her tale, this is clearly reflected. Her manner of speech, the way she addresses her companions and articulates her view of the surrounding world defines her person overall. Jovial and sociable by nature, the Wife creates an ambience of spontaneity and flow where guards are down and the entire crowd of pilgrims would respond to her tale with empathy. They might hold an opinion different from that of her, but they would quite openly consider her opinion for what it is. For the critic, Muriel Bowden, her characterization at the hands of Chaucer in the General Prologue also constitutes “a wide variety of love affairs; and, as we shall hear, the excitements and pleasures of travel. The Wife of Bath leads a systematized life for all its florid quality, and so her bold countenance, “reed of hewe”, escapes being blowzy and is attractive in its vigour.” (99). As a literary device, The Prologue as such, whether General Prologue or Wife of Bath’s Prologue, plays the important role of connecting with the audience. Indeed, the word stands for introducing the text. The word became quite popular in English writing after Chaucer employed it in *The Canterbury Tales*. In Chaucer’s poem, the audience consists of the travellers going on a pilgrimage. Keep also in mind the word holy land to which the pilgrims are proceeding. How it is a pilgrimage, how the members of the travelling group pilgrims and how the destination holy land or a place where the travellers would pay homage is well laid out by the poet under a plan. Chaucer uses in an effective manner his famous irony at many places in the text. This is to entertain the reader as also to tell her/ him that one should remain alert about the way the world goes. This will connect us well with descriptions in Wife of Bath’s Prologue that we shall take up at length in the following account.

The Wife in the Role of Teller of the Tale

The Wife talks about high qualities and “frailties” in humans. The context is of marriage, virginity, purity and self-control. These may be looked at from two angles. One is of being a strict adherent of morality in life’s affairs, whereas the second is of being lax, having weaknesses of the flesh, for instance. She is supportive of the latter. In her opinion, as she says,

I graunte it wel, I have noon envie,

Thogh maidenhead preferebigamie.

It liketh hem to be clene, body and goost;

Of mynestaat I nil nat make no boost

, For ye knowe, a lord in his houshold,

He nathnat every vessel al of gold;

Somme had been of tree, and doonhir lord servise.

God clepeth folk to hym in sondry wise

And everich hath of God a propreyifte,

Som this, som that, as him like this hifte. (95-104)

Mark these lines to decipher the message they contain. The Wife is no preacher, nor a pure person in her conduct. In fact, she is not a Christian observing rules of piety even as she believes in God, Christ and the Apostles. Her words are right and the practice is clearly faulty. But Chaucer has put in her mouth the central truth of human life. This passage presents the core of Chaucer’s wisdom and understanding. It expresses that doctrine of humanism Chaucer is famous for. After admitting that she does not meet the high standards

of righteousness, she asserts in her own inimitable manner the variety and diversity of men's and women's actions. The metaphor used to convey this is of a lord's household that has not all pots and pans of gold but those made of other metals coexisting with the golden ones. To her mind, different kinds of vessels serve a useful purpose and prove their utility to the household. The metaphor is cleverly combined with the humanity on planet Earth where every individual human being possesses this or that "propreyifte" (proper gift or quality) given to him/her by God following His "pleasure." In God's eyes, there is no strict hierarchy of importance among his creations. See Chaucer's linguistic precision: "And everich hath of God a propreyifte,/ Som this, som that, as him likethshifte" (103-4)

The Wife as an Interpreter The Wife has her own way of interpreting God's message, full of wit and courage. The twists and turns in her comment impress us as, for instance, her announcement that she as a human being is not duty-bound to follow God's words. Instead, she would observe the high principles in their breach, not observance. Further, she would use her energies for the fulfilment of pleasures (of flesh) afforded by marriage. To quote: "I wol bestowe the flour of al myn age/ In the acts and in fruit of marriage" (113-4). Here, "flour" signifies flower and "actes" acts. We might particularly comprehend the construction "fruit of marriage" that points towards joys of intimacy between man and woman. Chaucer's choice of words is exemplary, a method and vision that links him with life's realities in the surrounding world. She is aware that social codes and norms are human-made and serve the ends of living at levels of body and mind. This works at variance with supposed virtues of piety and chastity. The Wife of Bath is the woman of the world.

DONNE: DEATH BE NOT PROUD

Objectives

It is difficult to integrate John Donne with the stream of poetry in English. From the point of view of the period in which he wrote, he happens to be between Wyatt, Surrey, Spenser and Shakespeare on one side and Milton on the other. This is speaking merely in relation with his immediate predecessors and contemporaries—the latter were the Jacobean dramatists such as John Webster, Beaumont and Fletcher who presented states of mind that had no ideals to pursue. Indeed, the Jacobean period was of decline, not just economically but also in terms of the views and ideas that floated around. Ben Jonson, Marlowe, and Sidney were placed a little before Donne. Those who came later such as the Cavalier Poets kept an eye on narrow interests of seeking patronage also formed a category to be considered in the context. The Cavalier poets were royalists, in sync with the authority headed by the king. They constituted the circles of influence in the first three decades of the seventeenth century. More importantly, England in this period went through the processes of transition and instability. Apart from religion and ideology involving succession following the death of Queen Elizabeth, the crucial pressures emanated from the politics of the day carrying the burden of economic clashes and conflicts. Donne's early poetry and Shakespeare's mature plays, tragedies and romances had a parallel existence. We may also note that Shakespeare's increasing use of paradox in the later plays has a great amount of commonness with what is termed the metaphysical conceit

INTRODUCTION

Perspective was not the strong point of metaphysical writing. The overall attitude of acceptance or rejection that sifted grain from chaff and took a position was entirely missing from the writings of John Donne, Herbert and many others of the group. In them, there was not much to convey. It might indeed be asked whether poems of these writers led major critics to take note of them. Yet, there was something in the metaphorical verse that drew

attention. This may be termed the sense to engage with current thought, whether linked with ideology, religion or popular themes of love and rational appreciation. All these were there in the air. Certain it was that Metaphysical poets did their job of poetically expressing their intent.

They had no simple answers to provide to the current issues. What they achieved was in the form of formulating an honest opinion on the questions of the day. For instance, equanimity and balance were missing from the socio-ideological scene at the time. Admitting it as such was an act of courage, and pursuing it intellectually was a challenge worth taking up. What may have suited the environment particularly was a rational appraisal. Thus, intellect was employed to experiment, stretch, dare to seriously unsettle existing norms and show to the reader that all was not well with the period. Since that angible relations and affinities did not hold much hope, paths untrodden were explored. That they were called not materialist and deeply secular in their involvement might make sense. Yet, the word that captured the essence of this writing was “metaphysical.” This meant beyond the sensible, normal and sane. The examples that follow in this unit amply elaborate the poetic and cultural difficulties of the period.

DONNE’S POETIC SENSIBILITY

By poetic sensibility we mean the human faculty of grasping and interpreting the surrounding reality. Particularly, human beings evolve a manner of living to engage with pressures and problems of society. Those who write use specific words and phrases as well as a pattern of addressing the reader. All these come under sensibility. What do we say of Donne’s sensibility? For this, we may refer to the formative period of Donne’s life, the circumstances of which he was a part. In the previous unit, we saw in detail the ups and downs of his family as well as the phase of growing up. We also noted the crucial episodes of death that left an

impact on his psyche. For Donne, a life of activity, deep reflection and loneliness occasioned sharp and searching dialogue with self. His poetry is testimony to the fact that he was strained and troubled in the deeper layers of his heart.

In fact, the language he used for poetic communication presented themes that are discernible in his similes, metaphors and ironical observations. His poetic utterances were not assertive. Instead, they reflected a drama of pain and anguish. Questions of love, fascination, excitement and faith that he dealt with leave us wondering about his way of meeting requirements of the mind and the heart. Donne's poetic sensibility was shaped by what is known as the Anglican approach to the life's affairs in England. It had a mixture of rationality, individualism and sense of initiative. The seriously interrogative element in his poetry, the sense of doubt as well as search serves the dual purpose of capturing the surface and raising the mundane to a higher level. What Samuel Johnson called "violently yoking together" of opposites came from Donne's apparently flat perception that was rather mischievously combined with intellect. Was Donne serious in his poetic mission of giving sense to the weird? We certainly think so, since levity and deep concern for the unfolding truth was rooted in contemporary thought. This was the Anglican essence of Donne's way of grasping the truth of his time.

Death, be not proud

though some have called thee

Mighty and dreadful, for thou art not so;

For those whom thou think'st thou dost overthrow

Die not, poor Death, nor yet canst thou kill me.

From rest and sleep, which but thy pictures be,

Much pleasure; then from thee much more must flow,

And soonest our best men with thee do go,

*Rest of their bones, and soul's delivery.
Thou art slave to fate, chance, kings, and desperate men,
And dost with poison, war, and sickness dwell,
And poppy or charms can make us sleep as well
And better than thy stroke; why swell'st thou then?
One short sleep past, we wake eternally
And death shall be no more; Death, thou shalt die.*

Let us comprehend the meaning and message of this sonnet step by step. Note, for instance, that this sonnet has opened with the poet directly addressing death. Donne talks in the first person and initiates a conversation with the figure. This sonnet fits in with other sonnets of the period that were poems in the conversational mode. Here, the writer's choice of subject might appear conventional—death as much as love was a stock theme of the sonnets in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. For us in this unit, it is the treatment of the subject that makes the poem different, Donne being the shaping influence of the dialogue held between the poet persona and Death. Interestingly, the poet does not speak of the power of death or its inevitability. Indeed, he admonishes death for being too proud and suggests that for him death doesn't hold sway over the world nor can it overpower him individually. Note his tone in "Death be not proud though some have called thee /Mighty and dreadful, for thou art not so". The use of negatives "not proud" and "not so" creates an added emphasis. We may ask: Why does the poet show this stance of arrogance, and what can defeat death? He tells Death squarely that "For those whom thou think'st, thoudoest overthrow/ die not". Again, the use of the negative "not" makes it a statement of clarity. For the poet, Death is deceived in believing that it overthrows human life by claiming it.

It is conveyed that the case can be overturned and its opposite can be established with greater certainty. A person doesn't die even when Death apparently takes him/her away. Further, the poet calls Death "poore"—it is not human beings who are the subject of pity but death itself

deserves that denigration. Note the assurance in the poet-subject's words "nor yet canst thou kill me". Donne goes on to elaborate on the theme adding to it those characteristics of death that are nothing to be proud of. Death, he claims, makes a picture of sleep and rest, while life keeps on moving. As the best of men are taken by death, they are delivered of their bones and souls; they shed only the bodily form. Adding more features, Donne suggests that death lives in the company of disease, squalor and war. Simultaneously, the poet says that Death is a "slave to fate, chance, kings and desperate men". What is the connecting thread among these? Do fate, chance and the rest share a common trait? If not, what is the poet's purpose in bringing them together? Both fate and chance can cause deaths, kings can order executions, and desperate men unthinkingly may kill people. In any case, we are left to surmise that death is not free and is bound by these factors. We might wonder about the kind of life that death leads. Note the heightened form of personification. The irony is not missed that here Donne talks about the life that death leads. Note that the poem concludes with the foreboding, a kind of prophecy: "death thou shall die". It appears to be more than a paradox. The poem defines it as about the life and death of Death, thus making it a philosophical take on the subject. What could be the purpose of personifying death in this manner? Giving a human form to death renders it more palpable. We might then accept Donne's claim in the sonnet—"one short sleepe past, we wake eternally". The suggestion is that in view of eternity, Death would have no role to play. Donne thus strips death of its power as an independent agency. He suggests that to reach eternity we don't need death since "poppie and charms can make us sleepe as well/ and better than thy stroake". Death stands rebuked for swelling in conceit. In the sonnet, it is given the small figure of a non-entity

SUGGESTED READINGS

Allinson, Mark. "Re-visioning the Death Wish: Donne and Suicide". *Mosaic: A Journal for the Interdisciplinary Study of Literature*. vol.24, no.1, 1991, pp. 31-46.

Bauer, Matthias and Angelika Zirker. "Sites of Death as Sites of Interaction in Donne and Shakespeare" *Shakespeare and Donne: Generic Hybrids and the Cultural Imaginary*. Judith Anderson and Jennifer C. Vaught Fordham University, 2013.

Smith, A.J. *John Donne: The Critical Heritage*. 1983. London: Routledge, 2000

INTRODUCTION

To begin with let me tell you a little about the history behind the creation of this pastoral elegy *Lycidas*. Edward King, a Fellow of Christ's College, Cambridge, was a very good friend of Milton's. Edward King drowned on 10th August 1637. In 1638 a volume of memorial verses by King's companions and friends at Cambridge called *Justa Edouardo King Naufrago* was published. The first part of the volume is called 'Obsequies for Edward King, lost at sea, written by his sorrowful friends in love and remembrance'. The title is originally in Greek and Latin but the English translation reads as mentioned above. This volume of poems dedicated to Edward King contains twenty-three pieces of Greek and Latin verse. The Second part, titled 'Obsequies to the memory of Mr. Edward King', contains thirteen poems in English, of which Milton's is the last poem and the longest.

The preface to the volume which is in Latin explains that King's ship had struck a rock not far from the British coast and that caused the death of King. While other passengers endeavoured to save their lives, King knelt in prayer on the deck and went down with the ship. The Cambridge Manuscript contains many revisions made during the process of composition. Let us begin by looking at what an elegy and a pastoral elegy are as genres.

SONNET XIX ON HIS BLINDNESS

Let us begin by understanding what a sonnet is as we are going to examine Milton's Sonnet XIX On His Blindness in this section. Before we interpret the poem we will need to understand the form in which it is written – which is the Sonnet.

The Sonnet

A sonnet is a poem consisting of fourteen lines with a fixed rhyme scheme and it very often makes use of the iambic pentameter, which as discussed in BEGC 102, is five sets of unstressed syllables followed by stressed syllables for a ten syllable line. Sonnets were first written in Italy as far back as the 13th century by the poet Giacomo da Lentini (1210-60). The word sonnet is believed to have been derived from the oldest romance language Occitan wherein, sonnet meant “little song.” Over time, the sonnet form has evolved. There are two main types of Sonnet Forms – the Italian/ the Petrarchan and the English or the Shakespearean. Let us begin by looking briefly at the Italian/ Petrarchan sonnet next. Sonnets usually deal with the theme of religion, of love, or political issues. These early Italian poets were primarily influenced by the love poems of the troubadours from Provence, and from there on the influence of the sonnet form spread to Tuscany and other parts of Italy. Petrarch's Canzoniere — is a very good example of the Petrarchan sonnet at its height and is a sequence of 317 sonnets, addressed to his beloved Laura.

Milton's Sonnets

Milton practiced both styles of sonnet writing – the Italian and the English styles. Milton's sonnet structure was different from Shakespeare's which consisted of three quatrains and a couplet. Milton's Sonnet “On His Blindness” is a Petrarchan sonnet, a lyric poem with fourteen lines. This type of sonnet, popularised by the Italian priest Petrarch (1304-1374), has a rhyme scheme of abba, abba, cde, and cde (Two lines in the octave and three in the sestet). Another important aspect of the Shakespearean sonnet is that there is a turn, in the third

quatrain, whereas in Milton's sonnet style, you will recognise the turn in the middle of the eighth line. The central turn in the sonnet helps the thought process to turn on itself in the concluding lines of the poem.

Summary of “On His Blindness” and Analysis

This is one of Milton's most celebrated personal sonnets. Hence, the date of composition assumes significance when we try and understand the mood of the poet and it also modifies our interpretation of the poem. The available evidence points to three possible dates - 1644, 1651-2 and 1655.

John Milton's poem “On His Blindness” is an autobiographical sonnet in which he meditates on his loss of sight. This sonnet is an intensely religious poem with an abundance of Biblical quotations and an affirmation of Christian faith and virtue.

SUGGESTED READINGS & REFERENCES

A Milton Encyclopedia. William B. Hunter, Jr. ed. John T. Shawcross co ed. Lewisburg: Bucknell University Press, 1978. The Age of Milton: an encyclopedia of major 17th century British and American authors. Alan Hager ed. Westport, Greenwood Press, 2004.

Unit II

Poetry in Neoclassical and Romantic Age

ANALYSIS OF CANTO 3

AIMS AND OBJECTIVES

Our aim through this unit is to present a detailed analysis of Canto 3 from the poem ‘The Rape of the Lock’. At the end of the study of this Unit, you will understand:

- The characteristics of a classical epic
- What is a mock epic • the detailed analysis of Canto 3
- How Canto 3 incorporates a majority of the epic features.
- What makes ‘The Rape of the Lock’ both an epic poem and a satire?

INTRODUCTION

In the previous Unit, you were given a brief summary of the complete poem ‘The Rape of the Lock’ that consists of five Cantos. It is important to know the entire poem so that it becomes easy to understand Canto 3 which is prescribed for detailed study. The poem narrates a trivial incident involving two aristocratic families and this incident is exaggerated into a full blown battle, almost paralleling the classical battle between the Greeks and the Trojans depicted by Homer nearly two thousand five hundred years ago in his monumental epic The Iliad. The Iliad remains an epic poem and does not feature satirical elements like ‘The Rape of the Lock’ which is both a mock epic poem and a poetic satire. It is considered as one amongst the great satires of English literature. Alexander Pope and John Dryden were the chief poet satirists of this period while the celebrated prose satirist was Jonathan Swift.

THEME OF ‘THE RAPE OF THE LOCK’

Pope’s poem ‘The Rape of the Lock’ is based on a real life incident in which a British Peer, Lord Petre, fascinated by the beauty of an aristocratic lady, Arabella Fermor, clips a lock of her hair to preserve it as a memento. This results in a fight between the two families. John Caryl—a friend both of Pope and of the two families—requested Pope to write a poem satirizing the triviality and foolishness of the dispute and engineer a reconciliation between

the two warring families. Pope's 'The Rape of the Lock' is a masterly satire where he interweaves a real but trivial incident into an epic.

Pope modelled his poem on the theme and style of the Greek Classics, The Iliad and The Odyssey and juxtaposed the silly conflict between the two families with the battle between two mighty armies depicted in the great epics. Thus the poem is labelled a mock heroic poem. While the story is essentially about the triviality of the fight between two families over the cutting a ringlet off Arabella's gorgeous hair, it also mirrors the vanity and the frivolous life of the aristocrats in the 18th century. Pope uses the grandiose devices of the ancient Greek epics to mock the inanities and vanities of 18th century courtiers and ladies.

The basic themes of the poem are:

- the triviality of courtly life,
- the heroine Belinda's (who represents all the elite women) narcissistic obsession with her beauty,
- the vanishing of her lock of hair pointing to the short shelf life of youthful beauty,
- the ascendancy of the lock of hair to heavens to shine like a star in the sky forever, thereby reflecting the immortality of beauty that is best captured in art and poetry in contrast to the evanescence of physical beauty,
- the gender disparity in a patriarchal society that shows the male conquest of women (the snipping of Belinda's lock by the Baron).

THE MOCK EPIC POEM

Mock epic or alternately called Mock Heroic is a literary work imitating the style of heroic poetry in order to satirize a trivial or un-heroic subject. In short, mock epic attempts to create the feel of an epic without the heroic content. The three essential features of a mock epic are:

The tone employed is mocking or sarcastic Use of exalted style and form that one associates with an epic and

Treatment of a trivial subject

The epic tradition “was honed to a fine art in the late 17th- and early 18th-century Neo-Classical period. A double-edged satirical weapon, the mock-epic was sometimes used by the “moderns” of this period to ridicule contemporary “ancients” (classicists). More often it was used by “ancients” to point at the unheroic character of the modern age by subjecting thinly disguised contemporary events to a heroic treatment.... The outstanding English mock-epic is Alexander Pope’s brilliant tour de force ‘The Rape of the Lock’ (1712–14), which concerns a society beau’s theft of a lock of hair from a society belle; Pope treated the incident as if it were comparable to events that sparked the Trojan War.”

According to Oxford reference, “Almost invariably a poem in heroic couplets, the mock epic typically employs elevated poetic diction (which Pope said should generate ‘pompous expressions’), focuses on a single ‘heroic’ incident or action, and incorporates selected elements from the machinery of some classical epic. Although the mock epic satirical poem, which flourished in the later 17th and 18th centuries, portrayed real characters and events (often thinly disguised) in contemporary and local settings, its literary ancestry may be traced back to classical antiquity.” A close reading of the entire poem will show how far Pope has employed epic features from the ancient epics in his poem that has a trivial subject as its theme. We have spoken about the announcement of the subject or the theme of the poem and an invocation of the Muses as two basic features at the beginning of an epic. The protective armour given by the gods and goddesses is another epic device we can see in this poem. The poem has a rich range of literary allusions and an ironic commentary on the contemporary

social world with a sense of suppressed energy threatening to break through the veneer of civilization.

ANALYSIS OF CANTO 3

The Rape of the Lock': Canto 3

Close by those meads, for ever crown'd with flow'rs, 1

Where Thames with pride surveys his rising tow'rs,

There stands a structure of majestic frame,

Which from the neighb'ring Hampton takes its name.

Here Britain's statesmen oft the fall foredoom

Of foreign tyrants and of nymphs at home;

Here thou, great Anna! whom three realms obey,

Dost sometimes counsel take—and sometimes tea.

Hither the heroes and the nymphs resort,

To taste awhile the pleasures of a court; 10

In various talk th' instructive hours they pass'd,

Who gave the ball, or paid the visit last;

One speaks the glory of the British queen,

And one describes a charming Indian screen;

A third interprets motions, looks, and eyes;

At ev'ry word a reputation dies.

Snuff, or the fan, supply each pause of chat,

With singing, laughing, ogling, and all that.

Poetry in Victorian Age

Unit 3

Alfred Lord Tennyson Break Break Break

OBJECTIVES

In this Unit, we shall discuss some poems by the eminent Victorian poet Tennyson. After reading this Unit carefully, you should be able to:

- Describe the life and works of Alfred Lord Tennyson;
- Understand certain aspects of the Victorian age;
- Analyse the poems selected for you;
- Explain lines with reference to their context;
- Define Tennyson's poetic technique.

INTRODUCTION

In this Unit, we shall take up three poems by Tennyson. These are 'The Lotos-Eaters', 'Ulysses', and 'Break, Break, Break'. We have only been able to give you the concluding lines of 'The Lotos Eaters'. These lines are part of the celebrated 'Choric Song' that is a

masterpiece of powerful description, verbal felicity and haunting rhythm. You will also read ‘Ulysses’ in its complete form. Finally, we have selected a short lyric ‘Break, Break, Break’, for you. Before we discuss the poems, let us briefly look at some aspects of the Victorian age. This will give us an idea of the social and historical context.

From which these poems emerged. A quick look at the life and works of Tennyson will not only introduce us to the poet but will also facilitate our understanding of his poetry.

BREAK, BREAK, BREAK

Here is a short lyric by Tennyson that also happens to be one of his most famous short poems. We do not find any of Tennyson’s opinions expressed here, only intense feeling. The earlier poems in this unit are narratives. Here is an intensely personal poem written to express his grief over the sad death of his friend Arthur Henry Hallam. The sea is a powerful image that often recurs in English literature. This is because, England being an island, the sea is never far away. Let us imagine Tennyson standing on a beach watching the waves of the sea crashing against the rocks and grey stones. Beaches in England do not all have golden sands. In fact, many of them are full of grey pebbles. The poet’s heart is heavy with grief over his friend’s death and the scene in front of him only evokes a deep feeling of loss over what has gone forever. Let us now read the poem.

Poem

BREAK, BREAK, BREAK

Break, break, break,

On thy cold gray stones, O Sea!

And I would that my tongue could utter

The thoughts that arise in me.

*O, well for the fisherman's boy,
That he shouts with his sister at play!
O, well for the sailor lad,
That he sings in his boat on the bay!
And the stately ships go on
To their haven under the hill;
But O for the touch of a vanished hand,
And the sound of a voice that is still.*

Discussion

This is a simple poem expressing a deep sense of loss. The poet looks at the waves of the sea dashing against the cold gray stones and his latent anguish at the death of his friend Arthur Hallam surfaces once again. He wishes that he can give adequate expression to the thoughts that well up within him. The poet can see the fisherman's children: a boy and his sister shouting as they play. Tennyson also sees the young sailor boy singing in his boat as he sails on the bay. The joyous and playful shouting of the brother and sister and the cheerful song of the sailor are contrasted with the poet's own grief. Tennyson watches the impressive ships sailing towards their harbour below the hill. This sense of a journey safely completed, only induces the poet to acutely miss the soothing touch of the hand of his dead friend---a touch that can never be experienced again. He longs to hear the voice of Hallam but knows that it is forever silent! Tennyson observes the waves crashing against the base of its rocks. The sea seems to be in eternal motion, its waves continually dashing against the shore. The continuity in nature is in sharp contrast to the cruel finality of death and the passage of time. The pleasant days spent in the loving company of his friend are gone forever and will never return.

Unit 4th

INTRODUCTION

The Rambagan Dutt family were converts from Hinduism to Christianity. Toru - Dutt's father Govin Chunder Dutt was a good poet and a linguist who had published *The Dutt Family Album* (1870), *The Loyal Hours* (1876) and *Cherly Stones* (1881) along with his brother Greece Chunder, while her mother Kshetramoni had translated *The Blood of Christ* from English to Bengali. Apart from her parents, even her uncles were prolific writers. Mention of their contributions will be made in the next section of this unit.

Around the middle of the nineteenth century, a Bengali family by the name of Dutt, residents of Rambagan, Calcutta, came into literary prominence by virtue of their published writings in English. The Dutt's were an extremely well - connected family within the top echelons of Calcutta society. Nilmoni Dutt, Toru Dutt's great grandfather, had belonged to a tiny group of English educated Indians in the eighteenth century, even as the East India Company consolidated its hold over Bengal. Along with Raja Rammohun Roy and others, Nilmoni Dutt befriended certain Christian missionaries from England who had arrived recently in India. One of these Christian missionaries was Father Carey who subsequently founded the Serapore College, an institution next only in importance to the historic Hindu College.

TORU DUTT'S LITERARY CAREER

The first anthology Aru and Toru worked on was a volume of translations from French into English called *A Sheaf Gleaned in French Fields* which is without doubt the most well-known of Toru Dutt's works. The Indian edition was a large octavo volume of 252 pages of which 40 consisted of notes showing Toru's vast insight into French literature. Eight of the one hundred and sixty-five poems were by Aru, and the rest by Toru Dutt. The translations

were from about seventy Pamasian poets, including Du Bellay Du Bartas, Scarron, Mme. Viot, Pierre Corneille, De Parry, Le Compte de Gramont, De Florian, De Vigny, Chenier, Musset, Beranger, Sainte Beuve, Brizeux, Dupont, V de Laparde, Mine Ackermann, Victor Hugo, . Lamartine, Bandelaire, Leconte de Lisle, Mme Desloordes - Valmore and my others. Though she was chiefly concerned with the French Romantic poets, she did not confine herself to them. In her translations of Victor Hugo much of his variety and vigour of rhyme, metre and the splendour and sonority of diction is evident. These highlight his epic grandeur, his powerful descriptions, his lyrical skill, his humanitarian feeling and his deep patriotism. Many poems, particularly Hugo's are patriotic, others deal with themes such as - doves and butterflies and swallows, homely joys and simply scenes, kindness and bravery, childhood and ideal manhood. The subjects dearest to her were pathetic ones - those that spoke of separation and loneliness, exile and captivity, illusion and dejection, loss and bereavement, declining seasons and untimely death. Her own life was an odd mixture of sunshine and sorrow, laughter and pathos, beauty and tragedy, success and regret. Besides being inspired by the French Romantics, she was also guided by Elizabeth Barrett Browning, John Keats, and Charlotte Bronte and not least by Jane Austen.

The Saptahiki Sambad Press of Bhawanipore published the first edition of the book in 1876. There was neither a Preface nor an Introduction. The second edition was published by Saptahiki Sambad Press once more, in 1878, and included a memoir of Toru by her heart-broken father. This new edition contained thirty fresh translations and thus took the total number of poems to almost 200. The poems were regrouped and the book contained a frontispiece of Toru and Aru Dutt. Messrs Kegan Paul in London published a third edition in 1880. Sir Roper Lethbridge in the Indian Magazine and Review also published two of the translations in an anthology. He also wrote an article on The Poetry of Toru Dutt.

Toru Dutt: Poetry Summary and Analysis of Our Casuarina Tree

The poem "Our Casuarina Tree" is from Dutt's *Ancient Ballads and Legends of Hindustan* (1882). It is one of Dutt's most famous poems, and it describes a tree near the speaker's home that she associates heavily with memories of her childhood and her siblings that have since died, "Who now in blessed sleep, for aye, repose." The word "our" in the title hints at this significance—it is not just an ordinary tree for the poet, but rather a part of her life and an integral part of her childhood that she shared with her siblings. The poem's opening lines describe the grandeur of the Casuarina in minute detail, standing erect and wearing the "scarf" of the "creeper" that clutches it like "a huge python." The tree is a source of life, filled with "bird[s] and bee[s]," though the children who used to play under its branches are long gone. This liveliness that surrounds the tree is further detailed in the second stanza, which tells of a "baboon," "kokilas," and "cows" in its vicinity.

Still, in the third stanza, the speaker tells us explicitly that it is "not because of its magnificence / [that] Dear is the Casuarina to my soul"—rather, it is because of her memories of her departed siblings. At the thought of their deaths and their past memories, even the tree seems to "lament" and ushers forth "an eerie speech." In the fourth stanza, the speaker recalls various foreign shores (namely, "France or Italy") where she heard noise similar to the tree's mournful sighs, and recalled the tree and her "own loved native clime."